



By Kyle E Young



The Last Voyage Of The Penguin

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Inter-Island Ferry Named The Penguin, 1909, 12 February, 10:00 pm

The ferry groaned under the weight of the storm. Waves heaved and crashed against her iron hull as wind howled like a living thing, tearing through the rigging. Salt spray whipped across the deck, stinging faces, and fog rolled low and thick, swallowing the lamps' yellow glow into a pale, ghostly haze.

Elsie clutched her worn leather bag, its clasp broken, golden fragments glinting within as the ship lurched to port. She stumbled—first left, then right—each sway of The Penguin like the swing of some vast pendulum. Mary, her sister, clung to a railing nearby, her skirts snapping in the gale as the deck pitched beneath them.

Through the mist, a shape moved in the water—something vast, sinuous. A silhouette, slick and monstrous, rippled beneath the surface. Elsie froze. Then she felt a presence beside her: Frederick, his oilskin coat soaked through, a scimitar-shaped satchel clutched tight in his hand.

"It's followed us," he said, his voice barely audible over the storm.

Elsie's throat went dry. "Yeah."

Joseph, her brother, appeared at her side, his hand steadying hers on the bag. "We should get back from the edge," he warned.

Frederick's eyes burned. "We have to make it to the lighthouse before it reaches us."

But then the ship bucked violently, struck by a massive wave. Passengers screamed as bodies and baggage slid to port. Mary fell, a small green-glowing key tumbling from her grasp, spinning across the wet deck. Joseph hauled her upright, his boots skidding on the planks.

William, a deckhand, staggered forward, clutching the rail. "Is it behind us? Is it here?"

Elsie turned toward him, her voice trembling. “Yes.”

Hunter, pale and drenched, shouted from amid the chaos, “If it takes us—every death aboard will be our fault!”

All around, the ferry was alive with panic—men shouting, children crying, the captain bellowing from the bridge, “Everyone hold on!” The Penguin pitched starboard, timbers groaning in protest.

Hunter fell again, his satchel bursting open, scattering gold-worked fragments across the slick deck—pieces like Elsie’s. Together they scrambled to gather them as the vessel rolled and the sea clawed at the gunwales.

Then Joseph saw it. Rising from the black water—a tentacle thicker than a man’s torso, glistening in the lamplight. It struck the hull, coiling tight, dragging with impossible strength.

And then a voice—not heard but felt—echoed in his mind, a sound like distant thunder beneath the sea:

“You have taken my way home. I will take it back.”

The hull shrieked. The Penguin heeled hard to starboard, her iron belly tearing against hidden rocks. The deck split beneath their feet. Water rushed in, cold and merciless, as the great ferry shattered apart into the screaming night.

**Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi Point, 1909, 12 February,
11:00 pm**

The sea had fallen eerily quiet.

Elsie awoke to the sound of waves hissing against stone. The air was cold and heavy with salt, the night sky a bruised grey dawn breaking over shattered wreckage. All around her lay the bones of The Penguin — splintered timbers, torn lifeboats, and twisted iron scattered across the black sand of the coast near Tongue Point.

She coughed, tasting blood and salt, and tried to rise — only for pain to tear through her body. Looking down, she saw the jagged tip of a metal shard lodged deep in her stomach. Her hands trembled as she pressed down on the wound, warmth spreading between her fingers, dark and thick.

Through the morning mist, a shape moved — Hunter, stumbling across the wreckage, his coat torn, his face ghostly in the pale light. He dropped to his knees beside her.

“Elsie—are you all right?”

She gave a pained smile, her voice dry as sand. “Well... not exactly. You’ve eyes, haven’t you?”

Hunter swore under his breath. “Bloody hell. Maybe your sister—where’s Mary?”

He rose, shouting into the wind. “Mary! Mary!”

The only answer was the crash of surf and the groan of a broken hull shifting with the tide. Then, from behind a pile of debris, Joseph appeared — soaked, blood streaking his face, clutching Elsie’s torn shawl.

He knelt beside her, his voice urgent. “Hunter — find the portal parts. If they’re lost to the sea, the Kraken will claim them.”

Hunter’s eyes widened. He nodded once, then turned and began searching among the wreckage. The sand was littered with the dead and the dying — passengers sprawled like driftwood, their cries fading into the roar of the waves.

Then he saw it — Mary’s bag, half-buried in sand, faintly glowing from within. He bent to retrieve it... and froze.

A vast shadow loomed beyond the surf. A silhouette against the rising sun — enormous, serpentine, glistening with seawater. The Kraken. Watching. Waiting.

Hunter’s breath caught in his throat. He snatched the bag, ready to flee—

—but the sand beside him stirred. A pale hand reached upward, clutching weakly. Mary. Her eyes fluttered open, glowing faintly with white light. The ground around her trembled as small

trees burst forth from the sand, their roots spiraling with radiant energy, encircling them in a ring of living magic.

The Kraken struck. A tentacle slammed down—but the glowing trees held firm, their branches shattering on impact but buying precious seconds. Hunter pulled Mary free from the sand, her body limp. He threw her bag across his shoulder, scooped her up, and ran.

“Hold on, Mary,” he panted. “Hold on.”

Behind him, the trees splintered and fell as the monster surged forward.

At the far end of the beach, Joseph knelt beside Elsie, pressing his hands over her wound. “You have to keep pressure on it,” he said. “And when I say, activate the lighthouse spells.”

Elsie stared at him, eyes wet with pain. “Why are you telling me this?”

Joseph smiled sadly. “Because only one of us has to make it.”

The air shimmered around him — red light, pulsing like a heartbeat. Reality itself seemed to bend as he drew magic from the sand, shaping it into a blade of molten glass and crimson earth.

Elsie reached for him, her fingers streaked with blood. “Joseph... this was my mistake.”

He looked down at her, voice steady. “And I was meant to protect you.”

Then he turned, summoning the last of his strength. The beach erupted in a crimson blaze as he raised his blade. With a roar, he struck the ground, and the sand hardened beneath his feet into a bridge of burning glass.

He sprinted forward—leaping past Hunter and Mary—straight into the path of the Kraken.

Hunter collapsed beside Elsie, laying Mary gently beside her. White light spread from Mary's hands as she began to heal her sister, her breath shallow but determined. Together they watched as Joseph's silhouette clashed with the monstrous shadow, the red glow of his magic flickering against the dawn.

Out at sea, the Kraken bellowed and recoiled, dragged once more into the depths. The light of Joseph's spell burned brighter... then vanished beneath the waves.

And when silence returned, only the cries of gulls and the hiss of the tide remained.

**Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi Point, 1909, 12 February,
11:00 pm**

The sea burned red in the glow of distant lanterns and wreckage fires, the surf hissing as it devoured what was left of the Penguin. The once-proud ferry now lay broken upon the jagged New Zealand coast, her hull speared by black reef rock and her masts splintered into the raging tide.

Ernest hauled himself onto a floating plank, coughing salt water from his lungs. His hands trembled as he clutched the small brass key hanging from his neck — its inlaid crystal pulsed with a faint, blood-red glow, like the heartbeat of something alive beneath the waves.

The air was thick with the roar of surf and the stench of oil and smoke. Seaweed tangled about his arms as he blinked through the rain, his breath frosting in the cold southern wind. Then, through the spray, he saw a figure face-down in the water — a man drifting just beyond the reach of the next wave.

Without hesitation, Ernest ripped a length of rope from a shattered lifeboat and threaded it through the loop of his glowing key. He tied it tight around his neck and plunged into the frigid surf. The cold bit like knives, but he fought through it, reaching the man and turning him over.

“William!” he gasped — the man’s pale face slick with seawater. Ernest dragged him onto a piece of timber and pressed his hands against his chest, pounding once, twice — again and again.

Then William coughed — violently — salt water pouring from his mouth as his eyes fluttered open.

Ernest let out a ragged breath, clutching his friend’s face. “Will — thank God. You’re alive!”

William managed a weak smile, glancing around at the waves choked with debris. “Where’s my key?” he rasped.

They both looked around — the darkness shifting with the faint shimmer of something blue beneath the waves. Then Ernest saw it: his leather satchel, bobbing near the wreck, golden fragments spilling out — portal pieces gleaming like fireflies in the night.

“I’ve found the portal parts!” he shouted over the wind.

William nodded, teeth chattering. “Good. I see my key — meet back here once you’ve got them!”

They struck out in opposite directions, kicking through the debris and wreckage. Ernest reached for the satchel just as the sea itself seemed to move — a vast shadow stirring beneath him.

William turned toward the noise. The surface erupted.

A tentacle — black as night, slick with brine — surged from the depths, higher than the ship's mast had ever stood. The Kraken had followed them ashore.

The sea broke open in a roar of foam as William screamed, swimming against the pull. But the current was too strong. The tentacle coiled around him, dragging him skyward as the beast rose like a tidal wave, its massive form blotting out the stars.

"Will!" Ernest cried — but his voice was lost in the storm.

William fought, seizing hold of the creature's armoured flesh, climbing against the pull of gravity, his fingers slipping on the slime and suction. Lightning flashed — for an instant, the coastline appeared in stark relief: twisted trees, black cliffs, the sea alive with fury.

On the shore, the wind screamed through flax and pōhutukawa. Ernest swam toward land, every stroke burning, his muscles numb and his breath short. Behind him, William shouted something — a final cry — as roots and branches from the treeline began to twist and grow unnaturally, forming a living barrier between man and monster.

The Kraken smashed against it — again and again — the sound echoing across the bay like cannon fire. William clung to its back until, with a violent shudder, the beast flung him free. He hit the wet sand hard, gasping for breath, the world spinning above him.

From where he lay, chest heaving, he could see it — the monstrous silhouette moving away from him

**Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi Point, 1909, 12 February,
11:30 pm**

The surf was alive with ruin. Wreckage and shattered beams from The Penguin washed up on the black-rock shore, and the storm raged still — a southerly wind screaming down from the strait, tearing salt and rain into every wound the sea had made.

Through the crash of waves, Joseph charged — his boots lost to the tide, his coat torn — straight into the churning water where the Kraken writhed. Its tentacles glistened like oil in the lantern light, retreating only to strike again. Joseph's cry was lost to the roar as he vanished beneath the white-foamed breakers.

On the sand, Elsie fell to her knees. Tears blurred her sight; she could taste the salt of the sea and her own grief. Mary stumbled beside her, clutching her sister's arm, both knowing — even without words — that they would never see their brother again.

Then, through the haze and smoke of the wreck, Ernest appeared. His figure rose from the shoreline mist, burdened with two sodden leather bags — each heavy with the golden shards of the portal mechanism. His eyes burned with urgency.

"We have to reach the lighthouse," Elsie said, her voice breaking.

Hunter seized one of the bags and nodded. "Then we run."

They sprinted along the shingle shore, boots slipping on wet sand and shell, the surf clawing at their heels. Ahead, William staggered to his feet amid the wreckage, his own satchel half-buried in kelp. When he saw them coming, he waved weakly, clutching his ribs.

"Come on!" Hunter shouted, grabbing William's arm as they passed.

Behind them, the sea rose again. The Kraken surfaced — colossal, enraged — its massive limbs slamming into the earth, sending sprays of sand and water high into the air. The sound was like thunder over the strait.

Mary turned, her hands trembling as she whispered ancient words — light magic born of life itself. From the soil and salt-drenched roots, flax and pōhutukawa trees surged upward, twisting together to form a living barrier. The creature struck again and again, but her magic held, the forest groaning under the force.

They ran beneath its canopy, hearts hammering, branches clawing at their coats. Lightning flickered beyond the trees, lighting their path toward the distant headland where the Kahurangi Lighthouse loomed — its beam cutting through the storm like a single, steadfast eye.

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi Point Lighthouse, 1909, 13 February, 12:10 am

By dawn, the storm had spent its fury. The sea lay broken and heavy, rolling against the jagged coast with the low thunder of retreating waves. Smoke and salt hung in the air, and the once-mighty Penguin was now only splinters and ghosts.

Mary and Elsie stumbled up the cliff path toward the Kahurangi Lighthouse, their clothes torn, their faces streaked with sea and tears. Behind them came Ernest, Hunter, and William, carrying the last of the golden fragments in sodden canvas bags.

When they reached the iron door of the lighthouse, it creaked open before they could touch it. Standing there in the flickering light was an old man — weathered and grey, his eyes kind but shadowed.

“Mr. Abernathy,” Elsie whispered, her voice trembling. He had been their father’s friend once, long ago — a man thought lost at sea.

“I knew you’d come,” he said softly. “The storm brought more than wreckage tonight. It brought the end of something... and perhaps, the beginning of something greater.”

Inside, the moment the last of them crossed the threshold, the air changed. The faint hum of magic that had followed them since the wreck fell silent, like a breath held too long. Outside, the Kraken gave one final cry — a sound that shook the very stones — and then it was gone, sinking beneath the waves as if erased from the world.

All magic ceased. The light of the keys dimmed to a soft, mortal glow.

Abernathy led them down a spiral stair that wound deep beneath the lighthouse. There, beneath the foundations, was a cavern unlike any other — ancient and vast, carved by time and tide. The walls shimmered faintly with veins of gold, and at its heart was a stone dais, waiting.

They laid the golden fragments of the portal upon it. The pieces trembled, then rose, aligning themselves with the precision of fate. The glow returned — brighter than before — and the fragments fused into a single ring of light, humming with ancient power. A portal, once more.

Mary stepped forward. “What now?”

Abernathy’s gaze was solemn. “Now you divide it. Five keys — five magics — so that balance may remain. One for life, one for death, one for time, one for reality, and one for the soul itself.”

The keys took form before their eyes, each radiating its own hue — white for life, black for death, blue for time, red for reality, and green for soul.

Each was given to one of them, and in that moment, they understood: they could never stay together. The balance demanded distance.

They embraced for the last time as the lighthouse above began to hum with new energy, its beam sweeping across the dawn sea. The Kraken's prison had been made — the lighthouse itself now bound to keep the creature beneath the waves, forever watching, forever guarding.

The five families parted that day — one to the north, one to the south, one east across the sea, one west into the mountains, and one who stayed to tend the light.

They never saw each other again. But the beam of the Kahurangi Lighthouse still cuts across the waters of Cook Strait — and those who know the old stories say its light does more than guide ships. It keeps the deep bound.



The Ones Left Behind

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Big River, 2008, 20 March, 12:10 pm

The midday sun burned through scattered clouds, turning the surf and spray into shards of silver light. The roar of the West Coast sea echoed faintly through the dense green wilderness — rimu, kāmahī, and ferns whispering in the wind that swept in from the Tasman.

Ruby stood at the edge of Big River, boots half-sunk in the silt, her backpack heavy on her shoulders. In her palm, a small key glowed faintly green, its light shifting like something alive beneath glass. As she stared at it, a voice — not heard but felt — rippled through her mind:

“Take me to the Kahurangi Point Lighthouse... take me to the light...”

Her breath caught. Her eyes flashed the same green as the key, for an instant — a shimmer of otherworldly energy — then the light faded. She blinked, dazed, and slipped the key quickly into her pocket.

“Mary,” she muttered under her breath, thinking of her grandmother’s warnings. “I hope you were wrong about this key.”

Before her stretched a trail — rough, overgrown, leading through thick native forest toward the coast. The wind carried the tang of salt and the cry of distant seabirds. Tightening her pack straps, Ruby began to wade across the river, the cold mountain water tugging at her legs.

Halfway across, she noticed movement — a man ahead, stepping from the bush onto the far bank. “Hey! You there!” she called out, waving.

The man turned, startled, just in time to see Ruby lose her footing. The current caught her — the pack dragged her sideways — and she slipped beneath the surface.

“Oi!” he shouted, dropping his own bag and plunging into the river. The water was fierce, glacial, battering him as he fought to reach her. For a moment, she was gone. Then he saw her pack, bobbing — and dove beneath it.

He surfaced with her in his arms. She gasped violently, spitting water, her hair plastered to her face.

“Easy, easy,” he said, dragging her toward the shallows.

Ruby coughed, shivering, then met his eyes. “Thank you,” she managed, her voice trembling.

He smiled, breathless. “No worries. You’re lucky I was here.”

They made it to the far bank together, collapsing onto the wet grass as the river thundered past. For a moment, both simply laughed — exhausted and soaked.

Ruby shot him a glare, half amused. “What are you laughing at?”

He chuckled. “You don’t spend a lot of time outdoors, do you?”

Ruby pushed a strand of hair from her face. “No. I’m from Tokyo.”

He raised an eyebrow. “Tokyo? You don’t look like you’re from Tokyo.”

Ruby narrowed her eyes. “And what exactly do people from Tokyo look like?”

He hesitated — sensing danger — then grinned. “Honestly? I wasn’t expecting a beautiful, pale-skinned brunette with hazel eyes that could stop traffic.”

She blinked, caught off guard, then stood and offered him her hand. “Smooth. So where are you from?”

He took her hand, pulling himself up. “Egypt,” he said, smiling faintly.

Ruby tilted her head, teasing. “Egyptian? With skin like milk and eyes like the deep sea?”

He laughed. “Hey, at least I gave you a compliment.”

“Oh?” Ruby crossed her arms. “So you didn’t mean it?”

His grin widened, a glint of charm in his eyes. “I always mean what I say — especially when I’m talking to a beautiful girl like you.”

She rolled her eyes but couldn’t help smiling. He picked up his bag and nodded toward a narrow track winding through the bush.

“Come on. There’s an old cottage up the path — you can dry off there.”

Ruby slung her soaked pack over one shoulder and followed. “You still haven’t told me your name.”

He glanced back, the sun glinting off the river behind him. "It's Blake."

"Blake," she repeated softly. Then, under her breath.

**Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Big River,
2008, 20 March, 1:40 pm**

The sun had climbed high above the jagged horizon, turning the damp forest into a cathedral of gold and green. Ferns brushed Ruby's legs as she followed Blake up the narrow track, the rhythmic crash of the Tasman Sea never far behind. The scent of salt and moss hung heavy in the air, and every so often, a distant gull's cry broke the hush.

Ruby adjusted her heavy pack and glanced at him, curiosity flickering behind her hazel eyes. "So," she called, "what brings you all the way out here, Egypt boy?"

Blake looked back, a sly grin ghosting across his face. "If I tell you, you'll think I'm insane."

Ruby smirked. "What—like 'jumping into a raging river to save a total stranger' insane?"

He laughed softly, stopping in the middle of the trail. "Something like that." He set his pack down and unzipped it, the metal teeth rasping loud against the forest's stillness. From inside, he drew out a small black key — its metal dull at first, then glimmering faintly as it caught the light.

"My father gave me this," Blake said quietly. "Hunter Clark. On his deathbed, he said he found it here, in New Zealand. Said it wasn't just a key—he never got to finish before—"

Ruby's breath caught. "Before it spoke to you?"

He froze, meeting her eyes. "Yeah. How did you know that?"

She hesitated, then reached under her shirt and pulled out the pendant around her neck — a green key, glowing faintly as though it had a heartbeat of its own. "Because mine does the same," she said. "It whispers. It told me to come here... to the lighthouse."

For a long moment, neither spoke. Only the wind through the trees and the far-off boom of the surf filled the silence. Then Blake's voice dropped, low and uncertain.

"Do you think we're being pulled... toward something? Or someone?"

Ruby slipped the key back beneath her collar, its light dimming against her skin. "Maybe. But how many others are there? And why this lighthouse?"

Before he could answer, she turned — and there, through a break in the trees, the land fell away to reveal the distant headland. The Kahurangi Point Lighthouse stood tall against the sky, white and steadfast, the sea churning endlessly below it.

Ruby's face lit with wonder. "That must be it," she breathed. "That's the house you were talking about?"

Blake smiled, "Yeah. We can rest there tonight and finish the hike tomorrow."

Ruby grinned, a spark of energy returning after the long climb. "Race you to it!"

Before he could protest, she was off — sprinting up the trail, her laughter echoing through the bush. Blake blinked, notices his pack was open on the ground, gear spilling onto the track.

"Bloody girl," he muttered, snapping the zips shut. He slung the bag onto his shoulders, gripping the black key tight in his hand. "You're not getting there first."

He took off after her, boots pounding the damp earth, two figures racing through the ancient forest — unaware that, far beneath the cliffs, the sea had begun to stir again.

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Keepers House, 2008, 20 March, 2:10 pm

The forest finally broke open to a clearing, and there — perched on the windswept rise above the sea — stood the old Kahurangi Keepers House. Its weatherboards were faded by salt and years, and the sound of waves below echoed like distant thunder.

Ruby staggered the last few steps up the path and collapsed onto the grass before the porch, her breath ragged. “I won,” she panted, throwing her arms wide toward the sky.

Blake arrived moments later, dropping his pack beside her with a grin. “Yeah, by a second. If we’d started fair, I’d have beaten you easily.”

Ruby pushed the straps from her shoulders and let her bag fall. “A loss is still a loss,” she teased, smirking.

Blake shook his head, chuckling — but then his gaze shifted toward the house. The front door was ajar, a line of sand and footprints leading inside. Two other packs sat just within the doorway. His expression sharpened.

“Someone’s here,” he murmured.

Ruby rolled onto her back, shielding her eyes from the sun. “Why are you asking that out loud?”

“Because,” Blake said quietly, nudging the door open with his boot, “there are two bags in here.”

Ruby frowned, sitting up. “What are the chances someone else hiked this far out?”

“I don’t know,” he replied. “But they beat us to it.”

Before either could move, a voice called from inside — rough, male, and laced with an Irish lilt.

“Mate, what’re you doing in my house?”

Blake froze, then stepped forward cautiously. “Didn’t mean to intrude. Is there room for two more wanderers?”

The man stepped into the doorway — tall, disheveled, his hair a storm of spikes and sea-salt. He looked ready to argue, but before he could, a woman appeared behind him. Her hair was tangled by the wind, her clothes travel-worn, but her smile was warm and steady.

“Of course there’s room,” she said. She brushed past the man and offered her hand. “I’m Brooke, and this is Sean.”

Blake took her hand. “Blake. And this is Ruby.”

Brooke's eyes lit with curiosity. "Lovely to meet you. You're not from around here, are you?"

"No," Blake said, smiling faintly. "Egypt. Ruby's from Tokyo."

Brooke laughed softly. "Well, that makes four of us from everywhere but here. I'm from Canada. Sean's the Irishman, as you've probably guessed."

"Mixed company, then," Ruby said, still catching her breath as Brooke helped her up from the grass.

Sean nodded toward the hall. "I'll show you where you can sleep."

Blake lifted Ruby's bag. "We'll take whatever corner you've got. I can crash in the lounge — just need to set her things down."

Sean arched an eyebrow. "You two traveling together?"

Blake smiled, a little sheepishly. "Met her this morning, actually."

Sean chuckled, shaking his head. "Strange. I only met Brooke yesterday."

He led Blake through the narrow wooden corridor to a small spare room. The air inside smelled of rain and old pine. Blake set Ruby's bag gently at the foot of the bed.

"So," he asked, turning toward Sean, "what brings you to New Zealand?"

Sean's smile faded slightly. "A calling," he said simply. "Didn't know where it was leading... until now."

He walked back toward the porch, where the sea's wind carried the scent of salt and something older — something restless. Brooke and Ruby sat together on the steps, watching clouds gather over the far horizon. Blake joined them, the black key hidden tight in his palm.

Far below, beyond the cliffs, the water shifted — as though something vast had begun to stir beneath the surface once more.

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Keepers House, 2008, 20 March, 10:10 pm

Outside, the wind howled across the cliffs, carrying the restless breath of the Tasman Sea. The old keepers house creaked with every gust; its candlelight flickered against the walls like spirits dancing in the rafters. Inside, the four of them sat gathered around a weather-stained table, an open deck of cards and half-empty glasses between them.

Sean leaned back in his chair, grinning. "Blake, mate — grand idea bringing the cards."

Blake smirked. "Always do. They pass the time on long nights."

Brooke laughed, reaching for her glass. "And, of course, trust the Irishman to bring the alcohol."

Sean raised his bottle in salute. "You never know when you'll need a drink, lass. Keeps the ghosts at bay."

The laughter faded slowly, replaced by the steady crackle of the fire. Ruby glanced at Brooke, curiosity in her tone. "So... what actually brought you here? To Kahurangi Point Lighthouse?"

Brooke hesitated, tracing her finger along the rim of her glass. "You'll think I'm mad," she said at last. "But it wasn't really my idea. It was... a voice. Like something calling me — pulling me toward the lighthouse. I couldn't ignore it."

She reached into her jacket and drew out a small red key. Its metal caught the candlelight, shimmering faintly, as if it held an ember inside. She placed it gently on the table.

Ruby and Blake exchanged a look. Then Ruby whispered, "No way." She pulled the green key from beneath her shirt and set it beside the red one. Blake followed, placing his black key down next to them.

Sean blinked, reaching into his pocket. "That's... impossible," he murmured. "I have one too." He laid his blue key beside the others.

For a moment, none of them spoke. The four keys pulsed softly — red, green, black, and blue — the colors dancing across the walls like aurora light.

Blake exhaled, his voice low. "This is more than coincidence. Someone — or something — wanted us here together. The keys were meant to find each other."

Ruby leaned forward, eyes wide as the glow intensified. "Holy shit... they're the elements."

Brooke frowned. "The elements? What are you talking about?"

Ruby closed her eyes, resting her hands above the keys. The air around her seemed to hum. “My mother — and her sister, Elsie — taught me how to touch the weave of magic. They said there were five sources, five currents that make up everything in our world.”

Her voice softened, almost reverent. “Life — white magic. Reality — red. Time — blue. Death — black. And Soul — green. Together, they form the foundation of all magic. It flows through everything that lives, though only a few can hear it... fewer still can use it. Most people can command one power, maybe two. But to unite them all...”

Sean finished her thought quietly. “You’d have to be something extraordinary.”

He looked at the table, the glow painting his face. “So we’ve got Death, Soul, Reality, and Time. That means one’s missing — Life.”

The fire crackled louder, as if listening.

Blake leaned back, eyes dark. “We’re from all over the world — Egypt, Tokyo, Canada, Ireland — yet somehow we’ve all been drawn here. To this house. To this coast.” He glanced toward the window, where the faint beam of the Kahurangi Point Lighthouse swept across the forest. “Something stronger than coincidence is pulling us in.”

The light in the keys began to fade, one color at a time, until the room was lit only by the fire once more.

Blake picked up his black key, its metal cold against his skin. “We should rest. Whatever’s waiting for us... it’s at that lighthouse.”

He stood, slipping the key into his pocket, and walked toward the lounge, the floorboards creaking beneath his boots. The others remained seated, staring at the table in silence as the wind moaned through the old house — and outside, far across the dark sea, the beam of the lighthouse turned once more.



The Forever Watching Lighthouse

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Keepers House, 2008, 21 March, 1:00 pm

The sun blazed high above the Tasman, the white cliffs of Kahurangi Point shimmering beneath its light. Wind swept through the coastal bush, carrying with it the cry of seabirds and the faint, endless hush of the waves below.

Ruby and Brooke walked side by side, laughter echoing off the path as the old lighthouse finally came into view — tall, weathered, and still as a monument to time. Sean and Blake followed close behind, boots crunching over the gravel as they stepped onto the worn stone courtyard before the entrance.

Each of them held their key.

Sean approached first, the sea wind tugging at his jacket. He raised his hand and knocked on the heavy wooden door. The sound echoed — hollow, unanswered. He turned to the others with a half-smile.

“Looks like no one’s home.”

Ruby stepped forward, lifting her green key. The gem inside pulsed faintly as she held it toward the door — but nothing happened. No hum. No light. Just the wind.

“Maybe it needs all of them,” Brooke said, glancing at the others.

Sean grinned, resting his boot on the step. “Or maybe,” he said, “I can open it with my foot.”

Blake rolled his eyes — but before he could reply, a new sound cut through the coastal wind. A deep, rhythmic thumping. Growing louder. Closer.

Sean looked up. “You’ve got to be kidding.”

Out of the sky came a sleek black helicopter, its blades beating the air to shreds as it descended toward the clearing beside the lighthouse. Sand and salt whipped around them in a blinding spray.

“Get close to the lighthouse!” Blake shouted. They ducked low, shielding their faces as the helicopter settled on the grass, its engine whining down to a throaty growl.

The pilot climbed out — tall, tanned, and wearing aviator sunglasses that gleamed in the harsh light. He ducked beneath the spinning blades and called out over the roar.

“What do you think of my landing?”

The group stared, stunned.

He grinned and added, “Sorry — where are my manners? Name’s James King. Billionaire, pilot, collector of old legends, and evidently, the only idiot who flies this close to the coast. And you lot are...?”

Blake stepped forward, cautious but curious. “I’m Blake. That’s Sean, Brooke, and Ruby. Not many billionaires just happen to visit the end of New Zealand — what brings you here, James King?”

James shrugged, his smile sharp. “Can’t an American take a little scenic detour to see the old lighthouse at Kahurangi Point?”

Ruby’s expression hardened. She took a step closer. “You can hear it, can’t you?”

James blinked. “Hear what?”

“The voice,” Ruby said quietly. “You’ve got the white key.”

The billionaire’s confident grin faltered. Slowly, he reached into his jacket and pulled out a small, luminous key — its metal pure silver, its heart glowing with a soft white light.

“How did you know that?” he asked, the wind carrying a hint of disbelief.

The others looked down. Their own keys were glowing too — green, red, blue, and black, pulsing in unison. The air around them shimmered with energy as the lighthouse door began to hum and glow with engraved light.

Brooke’s breath caught. “It’s reacting to them.”

With a low, ancient creak, the great door swung open, flooding the courtyard with a beam of golden light.

Sean, squinting, smirked. “Still think I could’ve done that with my foot.”

The others laughed — nervously, awe-struck — as they stepped inside, one by one, their keys burning like stars in their hands.

James lingered behind, staring at the white key as if unsure whether to follow. Blake turned at the doorway.

“James — you coming?”

James looked up at him, the wind tugging his hair. He nodded once. “Yeah,” he said quietly. “I think I was always meant to.”

He stepped into the light. The door closed behind them with a sound like thunder.

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Point Lighthouse, 2008, 21 March, 1:20 pm

The air inside the lighthouse was cool and still, smelling faintly of salt and oil. Dust motes drifted through the narrow shafts of sunlight that spilled from the upper windows. The wooden stairs groaned under Ruby's boots as she stepped inside, her hand brushing the rough wall for balance. The others followed — Blake, Brooke, Sean, and James — their footsteps echoing through the hollow tower.

"Feels like stepping back a hundred years," Brooke whispered.

Ruby climbed the last steps to the landing and froze. There, in the dim light of an oil lamp, sat an old man in a weather-worn armchair. His clothes were simple, his hair a shock of white. When he saw them, he smiled faintly and rose, his joints creaking but his gaze sharp.

"You look familiar," he said, studying Ruby. "Do I... know you?"

Ruby blinked, taken aback. "I—don't think so, sir."

The man looked past her as the others reached the landing. His expression shifted — wonder, recognition, and sorrow mingling in his lined face.

"All of you," he murmured. "You've their faces. The ones who left me here."

Blake frowned. "Wait, left you here? You mean—someone abandoned you?"

The old man chuckled softly, the sound dry as paper. "Not abandoned, boy. Entrusted. Someone had to keep the light burning after they sealed the gate below. Tell me—" he turned to Ruby again, "your mother... she wouldn't be Elsie, would she?"

Ruby hesitated. "No. Elsie was my aunt. My mother was Mary."

A spark of recognition lit his eyes. "Ah. Mary. So Elsie didn't have children after all. I always thought she would. She was the brave one — and hopelessly in love with Hunter." His gaze drifted to Blake. "And you... you've his eyes. The same fire. The same stubbornness."

Blake stiffened. "You knew Hunter Clark?"

"Knew him?" The man smiled wistfully. "We built the portal together. That night still lives in my bones."

Brooke stepped forward, brows knit. "What night are you talking about?"

The man looked at her in disbelief. "Didn't they tell you? None of them?"

Sean's patience snapped. "Mate, I'm getting tired of riddles. Tell us what."

The man's smile faded. He looked at each of them — their confused faces, their glimmering keys. Then his voice dropped to a grave whisper.

“You came here to stop it. Just as they did.”

Ruby’s pulse quickened. “Stop what?”

He met her eyes. “The Kraken.”

The room fell silent for a heartbeat — then laughter broke the tension. Sean shook his head. “The Kraken? You’re kidding me.”

James snorted. “That’s the dumbest thing I’ve heard all week.”

But the old man only smiled sadly. “That’s what your parents thought too.”

Brooke’s voice was quiet now, edged with awe. “You knew all our parents?”

“Of course I did,” he said. “They were bound together by the same curse that binds you now — until they found those bloody keys.”

Ruby reached into her jacket and drew out her green key, glowing softly in the half-light. One by one, the others followed — red, blue, black, and white — the five colors shimmering on the old wood like living jewels.

“These keys?” Ruby asked.

The man’s eyes widened. “Impossible. They were scattered — hidden across the world. And yet, here you all are. Every generation runs from its fate, and somehow fate drags them back.”

Blake stepped closer, his voice firm. “It wasn’t chance. We’ve all heard voices calling us here.”

The man’s face grew pale. “Voices? Tell me — what did they sound like?”

Blake hesitated. “Like a man’s voice... muffled, like it’s underwater. It’s been in my dreams for weeks.”

The old man turned away, searching the cluttered shelves until he found a cracked leather journal. He flipped through its fragile pages with trembling fingers. “Hunter wrote the same words. Elsie too. They all heard him — the voice beneath the sea.”

He closed the book with a sigh that seemed to carry a century of weight. “The Kraken isn’t dead. It’s waiting. And now, it’s called you here for a reason.”

He looked up, his eyes suddenly fierce.

“The question is — why now?”

The lighthouse shuddered—first a low tremor, then a violent sway that rattled windowpanes and sent dust sifting from the beams. The floor pitched like a skiff in a gale; books slid, cards scattered, and the five of them stumbled, bodies knocking the walls like dice in a mug.

The old man lurched to the window. Beyond the white tower, the Tasman boiled. Far out past the reefs, something titanic breached and curled—a dark crown of tentacles rising, then diving with a thunder that seemed to crack the day in half.

He turned back—and the room was gone.

In its place: an older world, the same chamber lit by a storm-dark sky. On a bench beneath the window, Elsie lay bleeding, a jag of torn metal glinting scarlet at her side. The smell of salt and iron filled the air.

“It’s back,” the man breathed, dropping to one knee. “I don’t know how to stop it.”

Elsie’s mouth trembled into a brave, exhausted smile. “We never stopped it,” she whispered. “We only delayed it.”

“I wasn’t there when you froze it in time,” he said, voice breaking. “How did you do it?”

Her eyes shone. “Look where that got us. You have to send it away.”

He bowed his head, jaw set. “Only one of us has to make it. I was meant to protect you.”

“And you did,” Elsie murmured. “Now save them. Save Ruby and the others.”

The vision buckled. Wind roared; the walls reformed—the present snapped back into place.

A warm hand touched his shoulder. Ruby stood before him, her eyes flaring green for an instant, then softening back to hazel. The old man’s pupils brightened with the same green light, and as it faded, the years fell from his face. The stooped keeper straightened; the lines smoothed. In his place stood a young man in a salt-torn coat, eyes fierce and familiar.

Ruby’s voice was a shaken whisper. “How are you still here?”

He smiled—sad, astonished, grateful all at once. “When I charged the Kraken—held it as the others ran for this light—I knew I wouldn’t last. I made it to the headland broken and bleeding. They saw me thrown against the stones.” He glanced toward the stair, as if he could still see them. “Elsie and Mary tethered me to the keys—all the keys. If they were ever lost... or if the keys reunited without their keepers... a guardian would answer.”

Blake stared, breath held. “So... are you even here?”

The young man’s smile softened into something like peace. “No. I’ve been dead a long while.” He turned to Ruby. “But Elsie left a message for me—through you. I don’t know how, only that I heard it when you touched me.”

Outside, a deep surge boomed against the cliffs; the tower quivered. The five keys on the table answered with a low, harmonic hum.

The young man—Joseph—lifted his gaze, suddenly certain. “Now I know how to end this,” he said, voice steady as the beam that once saved ships. “I know how to stop the Kraken.”



The Secret Of The Church

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Point Lighthouse, 2008, 21 March, 2:10 pm

The wind outside had risen to a steady moan, the glass panes trembling in their frames. Inside, Joseph gathered the five glowing keys from the table, his hands sure and steady. Without a word, he started down the spiral stair.

Sean frowned, following him with his eyes. “Oi, mate—what do you think you’re doing?”

Joseph glanced back with a half-smile. “Back then we thought the keys were just keepsakes,” he said, his boots echoing on the boards. “They were never trinkets. They’re pieces of the portal itself.”

At the base of the tower he stopped, swept aside a frayed rug, and kicked loose a metal ring set into the floor. A hidden hatch groaned open, breathing out a draft of cold, stale air.

Up on the landing, Brooke and Sean exchanged a look; James raised both brows. “Yeah, no,” he muttered, stepping back. “I’ve already watched an old bloke turn young again—pretty sure that’s my quota of weird for the day.”

Joseph’s voice floated up from the dark. “You coming, or not?”

Ruby turned to Blake, her eyes catching the lamplight. “You in?”

He sighed, slinging his pack over his shoulder. “After everything we’ve seen? I’m not staying up here.”

Joseph’s voice rang again, firmer. “Come on then—before the tide turns!”

Ruby descended first, the others close behind. Brooke followed, muttering a quick prayer; Sean gripped the ladder with a sailor’s certainty. Last came James, shaking his head. “What the hell am I doing with my life,” he grumbled, then dropped into the hatch.

The ladder gave way to a narrow stone tunnel, slick with moss. Darkness pressed close until, ahead, a soft golden light flickered. They stepped out into a cavern hollowed beneath

the lighthouse—a vast chamber older than any of them could imagine. At its center pulsed a ring of gold, suspended above the ground, carved with five empty locks that shimmered like liquid fire.

Joseph spread his hands. “And here it is.”

Ruby stared, awed. “You built this... you brought a portal here?”

Before anyone could answer, Sean seized Joseph by the collar and shoved him against the wall. His voice cracked with fury. “Then why’s that thing—whatever it is—still out there? Why’s the Kraken back? What the hell did you people do?”

Joseph didn’t fight. He only smiled, weary and distant. “We were children,” he said softly. “Barely old enough to know what we were touching.”

Brooke stepped forward, her voice low but steady. “Then tell us, Joseph. Tell us what you did.”

Joseph smiles as he says, “Have you heard of the Heddal Stave Church.”

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, Norway, Outside Heddal Stave Church, 1909, 12 February, 4:15 am

The world snapped from red light to winter silence.

We stepped out of the portal into snow so cold it squeaked under our boots. Breath steamed white in the dark. Before us rose Heddal Stave Church—tar-black timber and tiered roofs stacked like a ship of shadows, dragon-head finials biting at the star-frosted sky. A ring of leaning headstones circled the churchyard, each stone furred with hoarfrost, the names half-swallowed by the night.

Ernest hugged himself, eyes wide. “Wait—are we truly in Norway?”

I nodded, feeling the ache of the jump still buzzing in my bones. “Yes. My family’s gift,” I said. “Red magic—reality. I opened my first portal at fifteen. More trouble than help most days... but on a morning like this, it a gift.”

Elsie slipped under Hunter’s arm, a grin thawing the cold from her face. Mary moved ahead, her skirts whispering over crusted snow. “Come on,” she called, delight bright in her voice. “Look at this place.”

The church’s great door yielded with a wooden sigh. Inside was a hush of old pine and cold iron, the air smelling of tar and candle smoke long gone. Pillars rose like tree trunks to hold the dim vault, every surface carved—knots, beasts, old saints peering from the grain. Our footsteps thudded soft on ancient planks.

William drifted to Mary’s side, his voice low. “Beautiful, isn’t it?”

She smiled, eyes lifted to the dark rafters. “Yes. Yes, it is.”

He wasn’t looking up. “I’m already looking at the most beautiful thing here.”

I cut between them without thinking, a look that said more than words. William only lifted his hands and wandered off, tracing the carvings with his fingers. Elsie and Hunter followed the nave, heads tipped back, wonder written plain across their faces.

“Is it as beautiful as you hoped, Mary?” I asked.

Her smile warmed the cold hall. “More.”

That was when I heard it again—the voice. A man’s, distant and drowned, as if speaking through miles of black water. It thrummed at the edge of hearing, drawing me toward the east end of the church—toward the carved altar screen and the tall wooden figure set above it.

I reached out.

The statue was cold beneath my glove—then warm—then alive. Grain flowed like muscle. Carved robes rippled, seams unstitched, and the wood itself bent and breathed. The figure folded inward, joints unfurling, transfiguring into a helix of boards and beams that spiraled apart with a sound like cracking ice.

Stairs. Of living wood. Descending.

Snowglow from the doorway pooled at my back; the passage below breathed a draft that smelled of peat and old secrets. Behind me, the others had fallen silent—Mary's hand finding mine, William's breath caught, Hunter's knuckles whitening on Elsie's shoulder, Frederick and Ernest exchanging a look that said we've come too far to turn back.

The drowned voice rose from the dark again, closer now—inviting, or warning. I swallowed, lifted the red key to cast its faint ember-light down the newly opened throat of the earth, and took the first step.

The air inside the church was heavy with pine tar and incense, the silence broken only by the echo of boots on timber and the faint whisper of the wind beyond the thick walls. The carved staircase of light led downward, spiraling deep beneath the ancient church.

Joseph descended first, the others following—Hunter, Elsie, Mary, William, Frederick, and Ernest—each step taking them further from the world of reason and into one carved from legend. Their breaths rose in clouds, mingling with the low hum of unseen energy.

At the bottom waited a round stone chamber lit by golden light. A single table stood at its center, and on it lay five keys, each shaped differently, gleaming with faint inner color—red, green, black, blue, and white. Beyond the table shimmered a golden portal, suspended in air like a wound in the world itself, pulsing with slow, living light.

Joseph froze. "What in God's name..."

Hunter brushed past him, eyes wide with wonder. "It's beautiful," he whispered.

Elsie stepped forward, entranced, fingers trembling as she picked up one of the keys. "I wonder..."

"Don't," Joseph warned, voice sharp. "You don't know what it will do!"

But Elsie only smiled, a flash of mischief and conviction in her eyes. "We'll never know unless we try." She pressed the key into the portal.

The air shivered.

Ernest, grinning nervously, grabbed another and pushed it in. "Well, in for a penny..."

Hunter and William followed, sliding their keys into place until four of the five glowed at once, threads of magic lacing between them.

Joseph, Mary, and Frederick stood back, the golden light reflecting in their eyes.

Frederick's voice was tense. "You don't know where that goes. It could open to the underworld—or just... vaporize us."

Joseph turned to Mary. "Don't."

Mary smiled faintly, lifting the last key. "Come on, Joseph. Live a little."

She pushed it in.

The world erupted.

Five colors blazed at once—red, green, black, blue, and white—spinning together until they fused into a vortex of pure white light. The ground shook. Wind howled from nowhere.

William stumbled back. "What the hell is happening?"

Then came the water.

It burst from the base of the portal in a surge of seawater, foaming and cold, flooding across the stone floor. Salt bit at their skin; the scent of the ocean filled the chamber.

"See what you've done?" Joseph shouted over the roar.

Elsie laughed, her boots splashing. "It's just water!"

But the water didn't stop. It poured endlessly from the portal, forming a shimmering pool. Hunter, grinning with reckless curiosity, stepped forward.

"Don't you dare—" Joseph began, but Hunter was already leaning in. His head disappeared through the light.

A tense silence. Then he pulled back, eyes wide.

Mary grabbed his arm. "What did you see?"

Hunter's lips curved into a stunned smile. "A dark blue sky... and endless water. Just water everywhere."

Before Joseph could stop them, William stepped through—and vanished. Then Elsie, laughing still, followed him, and Ernest after her.

Only Joseph and Frederick remained.

"This isn't right," Frederick muttered. "Why would the keys be lying here, waiting? Someone else meant to use this. Or destroy it."

Joseph nodded grimly. "Then we're already too late." He took a deep breath and stepped into the light.

Cold. Bright. Weightless.

He emerged onto a golden platform suspended above a vast ocean that stretched forever. The others stood around him, awestruck beneath a starless sky the color of deep indigo.

"We should go back," Joseph said.

William laughed. "Don't be such a crybaby." He scooped up a handful of water, watching it glitter through his fingers.

Then Hunter stiffened. "What's that?"

Joseph followed his gaze—and froze. Beneath the surface, something moved. A vast, dark shadow twisting through the depths, circling them.

"Get back through the portal!" he yelled.

The surface erupted.

A colossal shape surged upward—slick, black, and glistening with salt. Tentacles uncoiled toward them as Joseph tackled Elsie backward through the gateway.

The light flared as the shadow struck. The portal screamed. One great tentacle punched through, dragging half the creature into the chamber beyond.

"Break it!" Joseph shouted.

Frederick tore the keys from their sockets. Joseph unleashed red magic, fire searing through the air. The portal cracked, splintered—then shattered in a rain of gold.

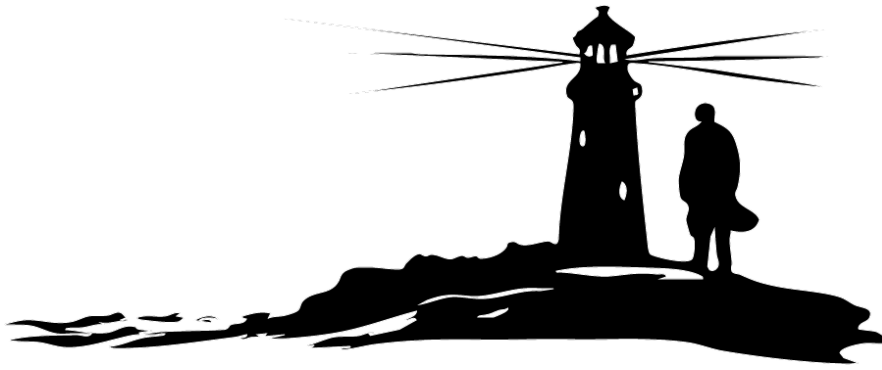
But it was too late. The Kraken burst through, smashing the stairwell apart as its roar shook the world.

With no time left, Joseph ripped open another portal—a desperate tear in space, glowing red.

"Anywhere but here," he whispered. "Home."

The air sucked them downward. The golden shards, the seawater, the broken pieces of the creature—all were pulled into the light.

And in the blink of an eye, the survivors—and part of the Kraken—fell through time and space, toward a place Joseph had only ever dreamed of—
New Zealand.



The Waiting Lighthouse

Multiverse Of Time, Earth, New Zealand, Kahurangi National Park, Kahurangi Point Lighthouse, 2008, 21 March, 2:00 pm

The spiral stairs groaned under their weight as Joseph led the descent. The air grew colder with every step, thick with dust and the faint metallic tang of salt. Behind him came Ruby, Brooke, James, Sean, and Blake—their footsteps echoing in the hollow tower.

Joseph's voice drifted up through the dim light. "You're carrying the missing parts."

Ruby frowned. "Missing parts for what, exactly?"

He stopped halfway down, turning toward her with a half-smile. "Were you not listening? The portal needs all five keys. It always did."

James adjusted his jacket, muttering, "In your story you could open portals whenever you wanted. So why not just make one and get us out of here?"

Joseph's smile faded. "Because I can't leave. My soul's bound to this place. I am its warden. And it—" his gaze dropped toward the depths below "—is still trapped here."

He continued downward. Sean leaned toward Brooke and whispered, "Maybe we should bail before the haunted guy kills us."

James overheard and snorted. "If I die here, at least it'll make headlines. 'Billionaire found in ghost lighthouse.' Great press."

The stairs ended in a cavernous chamber beneath the lighthouse. Water dripped from the stone ceiling; lantern light shimmered off a shimmering barrier of energy. Inside it, the Kraken floated—vast, chained in light, its black hide glowing with faint bioluminescence. One unblinking eye rolled toward them.

Blake whispered, "Why didn't you just send it back where it came from?"

Joseph stared into the shimmering prison. "Because I couldn't. I only trapped it ten years ago." His voice hardened. "And now I think trapped isn't the right word."

Ruby turned slowly. Behind them, the golden portal pulsed faintly, veins of light crawling across its surface.

"What do you mean, not the right word?" Blake asked.

Joseph looked troubled. "It wanted to be here. It came to me—as if asking to go home."

James crossed his arms. "Then why didn't you or your family send it back a century ago?"

"Because we couldn't," Joseph said. "We were missing pieces. Some of the keys were lost to the sea. Only recently did I find them all again."

Before anyone could answer, a sound rose—a voice, low and distant, as if spoken through the deep.

"Open the portal... take me home..."

Ruby's eyes went glassy. She stepped forward, lifting her green key. It glowed like emerald fire as she fitted it into the portal's frame.

"Ruby, wait!" Blake reached for her—but her hand was already turning the key. The portal's hum deepened. Blake's own key vibrated in his palm; he followed, pressing it into place. Sean and Brooke exchanged a look, then added theirs.

Only James hesitated, staring between the others and the creature stirring in the barrier. "If I put this in... do I get it back?"

Joseph met his eyes. "No. When the Kraken goes home, I'll destroy the portal—and the keys. Nothing else from its world can ever return."

James exhaled slowly. "Right." He hesitated, greed flickering behind his eyes. "Right."

He slotted the final key into place.

The chamber roared alive. The rocks trembled as Joseph raised his hands, red magic flaring from his palms to pull open the restraining wards. The force field shivered, then parted. The Kraken drifted forward, its vast form sliding toward the portal like a tide returning to the sea.

"It's working," Brooke whispered.

The creature reached the threshold—and then James glanced at his key. His father's voice seemed to echo in memory: Power is what you hold, not what you give away.

He yanked the key free.

“James, no!” Joseph shouted.

The Kraken was half through the gate when the portal convulsed. Gold light fractured; the energy began to collapse in on itself. The air turned white with heat.

Joseph’s face hardened. “Run!”

Ruby grabbed Brooke’s arm, dragging her toward the stairs. Sean shoved James ahead, cursing, as the floor began to shake. Joseph stayed behind, red light blazing around him, trying to contain the implosion. The Kraken screamed, a sound like the tearing of oceans.

Outside, the others burst into the daylight, sand and wind whipping around them. The lighthouse blazed from within, its glass crown burning crimson.

Blake spun on James. “What the hell did you just do?”

James held up the dissolving key, its metal flaking into ash. “That key powered my father’s company—it built everything I own. I wasn’t about to give it up.”

Sean glared at him, bitter laughter breaking through his shock. “And you doomed us all—for nothing.”

The lighthouse shone brighter, the beam now blood-red. A thunderclap split the sky. The explosion tore through the air, a shockwave hurling them all backward.

Ruby hit the ground hard, sand and salt filling her lungs. When she looked up, the Kahurangi Point Lighthouse was a pillar of red flame—its light cutting the sky like the end of the world.

The world did not end.

The skies over Kahurangi cleared, and the sea returned to its restless calm. Time—slow and patient—wove over the scars of that day, and life went on.

Blake and Ruby left the coast together, bound by fire and memory. They built a quiet life far from the roar of the sea, though every now and then Ruby would wake from dreams of green light and endless water.

Brooke and Sean drifted apart. Distance and time pulled them to different worlds, yet they never forgot the storm, the keys, or the sound of the Kraken’s cry fading beneath the waves. As for James—his empire crumbled, fortune lost to guilt and ghosts. The key he’d tried to keep had taken everything from him before turning to dust.

And still, every five years, on the 21st of March, they all returned. The survivors gathered once more at Kahurangi Point Lighthouse, standing in the wind where the cliffs met the endless Tasman.

They would bring flowers, light a lantern, and stare out toward the horizon where the sea burned gold in the fading sun.

Each of them swore they'd seen him.

A lone man standing beside the old lighthouse—coat whipping in the wind, eyes fixed on the sea. A silhouette outlined by the beam of light, fading as the fog rolled in.

Some said it was just the mist. Others swore it was Joseph, still watching over the coast—still guarding the line between this world and the next.

And as the waves crashed far below, they couldn't help but wonder:

Was the Kraken truly gone... or merely waiting, beneath the dark, for the light to fade once more?